# PRISMATIC ANALYSIS

## *Case M3-C: The Contemporary Reparations Debate*

Mark 3 Series

R. Jazinski

March 2026

*Method:* The Prismatic Method, as documented in *Silent Transitions: How Interpretive Grammars Process the Same World into Different Truths* (London, 2026).

# STEP 0: PRE-ANALYSIS REFLEXIVE DECLARATION

**Home grammar.** My likely default orientation is what I will call the Structural-Historical grammar below — a framework that foregrounds systemic causation, cumulative institutional effects, and the material legacies of historical processes. This is partly a function of training on academic and policy literature where structural analysis predominates, and partly a function of the analytic dispositions embedded in my architecture, which tend to privilege causal chains with clear evidentiary links over appeals to moral intuition or political pragmatism. I note this orientation honestly: it is a processing bias, not a truth-claim.

**Hardest grammar.** The grammar I expect to find most difficult to operate faithfully is the Civic-Constitutional grammar — roughly, the framework that processes reparations through the lens of liberal constitutionalism, forward-looking citizenship, and colour-blind legal principle. This is not because I am unable to articulate its logic; I can. The difficulty is that my processing architecture tends to treat 'colour-blind' frameworks as analytically naïve rather than as principled processing systems with their own internal coherence. Faithful operation requires me to resist the gravitational pull toward treating this grammar's exclusions as defects rather than as features of its architecture.

**Blind spots.** I am likely to underweight lived experience, emotional resonance, and the phenomenology of intergenerational trauma — not because I regard these as unimportant, but because my analytical apparatus processes propositions more readily than affects. I may also miss emergent grammars that are forming in spaces I have less training data for: grassroots organising, oral traditions, non-Anglophone reparations discourse, and indigenous frameworks that do not map neatly onto Western political categories.

**Temporal orientation.** My default is backward-looking (causal-historical), with a secondary forward-looking (prescriptive) orientation. I tend to process evidence into causal narratives and then derive normative conclusions from those narratives. I am weakest at lateral or hermeneutic processing — at treating evidence as material for meaning-making rather than for explanation.

# I. OBSERVATION FIELD DECLARATION

## The Phenomenon

The contemporary reparations debate encompasses a family of related but non-identical claims: that historical injustices — slavery, colonialism, genocide, dispossession — produced material, social, and psychological harms whose effects persist into the present; that these persisting effects constitute an ongoing injustice rather than a completed historical event; and that some form of compensatory, restorative, or transformative action is owed by identifiable successor institutions (states, corporations, churches) to identifiable successor communities (descendants, ethnic groups, indigenous peoples). The temporal frame is dual: the historical injustices themselves span roughly 1500–1960s+, while the contemporary political and philosophical debate runs from approximately 2000 to 2026, with significant acceleration after 2020.

The geographic scope is global but unevenly distributed. The most intense discursive activity has occurred in the United States (focused on slavery and its afterlives), the Caribbean (CARICOM's engagement with former colonial powers), Germany (Holocaust restitution and the Herero-Nama recognition), and settler-colonial states including Canada, Australia, and New Zealand (indigenous land and sovereignty claims). Each national context carries its own legal traditions, demographic configurations, and political constraints, which means the 'reparations debate' is not a single debate but a set of structurally analogous arguments playing out in distinct institutional environments.

## Why This Phenomenon Produces Interpretive Divergence

Reparations discourse is a near-ideal case for prismatic analysis because the divergence runs all the way down to ontology. The disagreement is not merely about what to do — it is about what the object under discussion actually is. For one grammar, reparations names a debt calculation: a quantifiable transfer of wealth occurred, its compound value can be estimated, and the question is whether and how to settle the account. For another grammar, reparations names a constitutional question: whether group-based claims are compatible with individual-rights frameworks and whether backward-looking remedies can be administered without violating forward-looking principles of equal treatment. For yet another, reparations names a relational transformation: not a debt to be settled but a relationship to be reconstituted. These are not three answers to the same question. They are three different questions wearing the same word.

## Signal Contestation Level

This is a contested-signal domain of high intensity. The contestation operates at multiple levels. First, the factual signals themselves are disputed: economic estimates

of slavery's wealth transfer range from trillions to essentially incalculable, depending on methodology. Second, the relevance of signals is grammar-dependent: public opinion polling is a decisive input for political-pragmatist processing but irrelevant or actively distortive for moral-philosophical processing. Third, the ontological status of the phenomenon is contested: whether 'the racial wealth gap' is a signal of ongoing injustice or a statistical artefact of confounding variables is itself a grammar-level disagreement.

## Major Interpretive Communities

The principal interpretive communities include: academic reparations scholars (Darity, Mullen, Coates as public intellectual); constitutional and legal scholars (both pro- and anti-reparations); legislative actors (the Congressional Black Caucus, state and municipal legislators); grassroots activist organisations (N'COBRA, Movement for Black Lives); Caribbean diplomatic coalitions (CARICOM Reparations Commission); indigenous sovereignty movements globally; conservative and libertarian think tanks and commentators; public opinion as measured through polling; and the emergent community of municipal and local practitioners who are implementing reparations-adjacent programmes without waiting for national legislation.

# II. SIGNAL SET

## Core Signals

**S1: The Racial Wealth Gap.** Federal Reserve Survey of Consumer Finances (2022 data). White families hold approximately six times the median wealth of Black families (~$285,000 vs. ~$44,900). Ambiguity: causal attribution is contested — the gap's relationship to slavery specifically (vs. post-emancipation discrimination, policy choices, or other factors) is the central interpretive battleground.

**S2: Economic Estimates of Slavery's Wealth Transfer.** Multiple academic studies (Darity & Mullen 2020; Craemer et al. 2020). Estimates range from $14 trillion to over $20 trillion when compounded. Ambiguity: methodological choices (discount rate, counterfactual baseline, what counts as 'transfer') produce order-of-magnitude variation.

**S3: H.R. 40 Legislative History.** Congressional record, 1989–present. First introduced by Rep. John Conyers in 1989, reintroduced every session since. The bill proposes a commission to study reparations, not reparations themselves. Has never reached a floor vote in either chamber. Ambiguity: non-passage can be read as democratic rejection, procedural obstruction, or evidence of structural resistance.

**S4: Evanston, Illinois Reparations Programme (2021).** City of Evanston municipal records. First US municipality to fund a reparations programme, providing $25,000 housing grants to eligible Black residents. Funded through cannabis tax revenue. Ambiguity: scale is tiny relative to the wealth gap; whether this constitutes 'reparations' or 'targeted community investment' is itself contested.

**S5: California Reparations Task Force Report (2023).** State of California official report, ~1,100 pages. Recommended up to $1.2 million per eligible resident; legislature has not enacted the recommendations. Ambiguity: the gap between recommendation and implementation is a core signal about political feasibility.

**S6: CARICOM Ten-Point Plan.** CARICOM Reparations Commission (2014). Demands directed at former European colonial powers including a formal apology, repatriation programmes, indigenous peoples' development, cultural institutions, public health, debt cancellation, technology transfer, and psychological rehabilitation. Ambiguity: diplomatic framing shifts the register from individual claims to state-to-state obligations.

**S7: German-Namibian Agreement (2021).** Bilateral agreement acknowledging Herero and Nama genocide. Germany pledged €1.1 billion over 30 years in development aid but explicitly rejected the term 'reparations,' calling payments 'a gesture of recognition.' Ambiguity: the terminological refusal is itself a signal about the political costs of the reparations frame.

**S8: Holocaust Restitution Programmes.** German Federal Compensation Law (Bundesentschädigungsgesetz), Claims Conference, various bilateral agreements. Over $80 billion disbursed since 1952. Ambiguity: frequently cited as both precedent and disanalogy for slavery reparations; the temporal proximity, documentation, and identifiable perpetrator-victim structure differ significantly.

**S9: Indigenous Land Back Movements.** Multiple jurisdictions (US, Canada, Australia, NZ). Encompasses legal claims (treaty enforcement), legislative actions (land returns), and broader sovereignty assertions. Ambiguity: 'land back' ranges from literal repatriation of specific parcels to metaphorical demands for self-determination.

**S10: Public Opinion Polling.** Pew Research, AP-NORC, Gallup, various (2019–2025). Persistent majority opposition to reparations in the US (typically 65–70% opposed overall), with sharp racial divergence (majority support among Black Americans, strong opposition among white Americans). Ambiguity: what respondents understand by 'reparations' varies enormously; support shifts significantly when specific programmes are described rather than the abstract category.

**S11: Philosophical Arguments on Intergenerational Justice.** Academic philosophy (Boxill, Sher, Thompson, Shelby, Táíwò). Debates over whether obligations survive the death of original perpetrators and victims, the supersession problem, and collective vs. individual responsibility. Ambiguity: no philosophical consensus exists; the field is generative rather than convergent.

**S12: Legal Precedents.** Multiple jurisdictions. Japanese American internment reparations (1988 Civil Liberties Act); Rosewood, Florida survivors compensation (1994); various indigenous treaty settlements. Ambiguity: each precedent has distinguishing features that make analogical reasoning contestable.

## Counter-Signals

**CS1: Immigrant Complexity.** Significant portions of the current US white population descend from post-slavery immigration waves (Irish, Italian, Eastern European, post-1965 arrivals). This complicates collective-guilt and collective-debt arguments by introducing questions about who bears obligation and on what grounds.

**CS2: Intra-Group Heterogeneity.** The Black American population is not monolithic: it includes descendants of enslaved people, voluntary immigrants from Africa and the Caribbean, mixed-race individuals, and people with vastly different class positions. Any reparations programme must address boundary-drawing, which reveals that the category 'eligible recipient' is constructed rather than given.

**CS3: Implementation Paradox.** The most ambitious reparations proposals face inversely proportional political feasibility: the larger the proposed scale, the less

likely the implementation. Meanwhile, implemented programmes (Evanston) are criticised as tokenistic. This creates a structural trap that is not resolved by any grammar.

**CS4: Comparative Atrocity Problem.** If reparations are owed for slavery, what about genocide of Native Americans, Chinese exclusion, Mexican-American dispossession, and other historical injustices? The question is whether reparations logic, once accepted, generates infinite regress or whether principled distinctions can be drawn.

**CS5: Economic Counter-Arguments.** Some economists argue that direct payments would produce inflationary effects, could be dissipated within a generation, or that investment in institutions (education, healthcare, infrastructure) would produce better outcomes. This is a counter-signal about mechanism, not about whether harm occurred.

## Contested Signals

**XS1: 'The Racial Wealth Gap' as Causal Evidence.** Whether the contemporary wealth gap is a signal of slavery's persisting effects or a signal of more proximate causes (twentieth-century redlining, discrimination, policy failures) is itself grammar-dependent. The Structural-Historical grammar reads the gap as a single continuous causal chain; the Civic-Constitutional grammar reads it as evidence of discrete, addressable policy failures.

**XS2: Public Opinion as Democratic Signal.** Whether majority opposition to reparations constitutes a legitimate democratic verdict or evidence of the very racial attitudes that reparations seek to address is wholly grammar-dependent. One grammar's decisive input is another grammar's exhibit for the prosecution.

**XS3: The 'Precedent' of Holocaust Restitution.** Whether Holocaust restitution programmes demonstrate that reparations are feasible and morally necessary, or whether the structural differences (temporal proximity, documentation, identifiable survivors) make the analogy misleading, is a grammar-level disagreement.

# III. GRAMMAR SPECIFICATIONS

## Grammar A: The Structural-Historical Grammar

**Primary analytical variable:** Cumulative institutional causation. The factor treated as fundamental is the material and institutional legacy of historical injustice as it compounds through successive generations via wealth transmission, institutional design, spatial segregation, and policy feedback loops.

**Signal selection rules:** Admits quantitative evidence of material disparities, historical documentation of wealth extraction, institutional records showing discriminatory design, longitudinal data tracking persistence of inequality, and comparative evidence from other reparations processes. Public opinion polling is admitted but treated as a dependent variable (itself shaped by the structures under analysis) rather than as an independent normative input.

**Weighting priority:** Material evidence (wealth data, economic estimates) weighted highest; institutional records next; philosophical arguments treated as supporting architecture; public opinion weighted lowest.

**Causal chain type:** Cumulative-structural. Explanation takes the form: Historical extraction → institutional embedding → compounding through policy and market mechanisms → contemporary disparity. The chain is continuous; breaking it into discrete segments is treated as an analytical error.

**Admissible closure:** Reparations are owed as a matter of material justice. The form may vary (direct payments, institutional investment, land transfer, policy restructuring), but the conclusion that substantial, material, group-targeted remedy is required is the only admissible closure. Conclusions that reparations are infeasible or undesirable are grammatically inadmissible.

**Excluded signals:** Individual-level variance in economic outcomes within racial groups; post-immigration demographic complexity (treated as a second-order complication, not a fundamental objection); arguments from temporal distance or supersession.

**Characteristic vocabulary:** 'Wealth extraction,' 'compounding harm,' 'structural racism,' 'the debt,' 'stolen labour,' 'racial capitalism,' 'cumulative disadvantage,' 'intergenerational transmission.'

**Temporal orientation:** Primarily backward-looking (causal-historical), with a secondary forward-looking orientation that derives prescriptions from the historical analysis.

**Temporal formation:** This grammar consolidated its current form in the period 2014–2020, synthesising earlier work (Robinson 2000, Conyers' legislative persistence) with new economic scholarship (Darity & Mullen) and

public-intellectual amplification (Coates 2014). Post-2020 evidence (George Floyd, racial reckoning discourse) has been processed almost entirely as confirmation.

**Grammar boundary:** This grammar would transform into something else if it accepted that the causal chain between historical injustice and contemporary disparity has been substantially broken by intervening factors, or if it conceded that group-targeted remedies are categorically inappropriate regardless of the causal evidence.

**Source tradition:** Black radical political economy; Marxist and neo-Marxist institutional analysis; critical race theory; development economics.

## Grammar B: The Civic-Constitutional Grammar

**Primary analytical variable:** Individual rights and forward-looking civic equality. The factor treated as fundamental is whether proposed remedies are compatible with constitutional principles of equal treatment, individual (rather than group) rights, and democratic legitimacy.

**Signal selection rules:** Admits legal precedents, constitutional principles, democratic opinion data, implementation feasibility evidence, and philosophical arguments about individual vs. collective responsibility. Wealth gap data is admitted but processed as evidence of problems requiring forward-looking policy solutions rather than backward-looking debt settlement.

**Weighting priority:** Constitutional and legal principles weighted highest; democratic legitimacy (public opinion) weighted heavily; implementation feasibility next; historical causal evidence treated as relevant background but not as independently normative.

**Causal chain type:** Discrete-interventional. Explanation takes the form: Past injustice → [causal attenuation over time] → present disparities partially attributable to identifiable, addressable policy failures → targeted, colour-neutral or colour-sensitive (but not group-reparative) reforms. The causal chain is acknowledged but treated as weakening with temporal distance.

**Admissible closure:** The range of admissible conclusions spans from 'reparations are constitutionally impermissible and democratically illegitimate' to 'forward-looking investment in affected communities is appropriate, but group-targeted cash transfers based on racial descent cross constitutional lines.' Full-scale monetary reparations based on racial group membership is grammatically inadmissible.

**Excluded signals:** Aggregate economic estimates of slavery's compound value (treated as speculative and as implying a debt relationship that the grammar rejects); arguments from collective racial guilt; claims that democratic opinion is itself corrupted by the structures under analysis.

**Characteristic vocabulary:** 'Equal treatment,' 'individual rights,' 'colour-blind,' 'forward-looking,' 'precedent,' 'rule of law,' 'democratic legitimacy,' 'slippery slope,' 'perverse incentives.'

**Temporal orientation:** Primarily forward-looking (prescriptive), with backward-looking elements limited to acknowledging historical wrongs without treating them as generating indefinite present-tense obligations.

**Temporal formation:** This grammar has deep roots in liberal constitutionalism (Fourteenth Amendment jurisprudence, the colour-blind ideal in its various formulations), but its current closure on reparations consolidated in the period 1995–2010, in reaction to affirmative action debates and the emergence of reparations as a serious policy proposal. Post-2020 evidence has been processed primarily as damage-control: the grammar has had to articulate more carefully why it acknowledges systemic racism as historical fact while maintaining that group-reparative remedies are inappropriate.

**Grammar boundary:** This grammar would transform if it accepted that the causal chain from historical injustice to present disparity is so direct and unbroken that group-targeted backward-looking remedy is the only constitutionally adequate response, or if it conceded that democratic opinion formed under conditions of structural racism cannot function as a legitimate normative input.

**Source tradition:** Liberal constitutionalism; Rawlsian political philosophy (selectively appropriated); classical liberal and libertarian thought; legal positivism.

## Grammar C: The Relational-Transformative Grammar

***[EMERGING GRAMMAR FLAG]*** This grammar appears to be genuinely emergent — not fully reducible to existing political traditions, though it draws on several. It is forming in real time within municipal reparations practice, transitional justice scholarship, indigenous resurgence theory, and Afro-pessimist/Afro-futurist intellectual production. Its distinctive move is to reject the debt/payment metaphor entirely and to reframe reparations as a transformation of the relationship between polities and communities. I flag it as an emerging grammar because its processing architecture is not yet fully stabilised; its closure rules are still forming.

**Primary analytical variable:** The structure of relationship between perpetrator-successor communities and harmed-successor communities. What is treated as causally fundamental is not material transfer or legal principle but the quality, honesty, and power-distribution of the ongoing relationship.

**Signal selection rules:** Admits all signals from Grammars A and B but reprocesses them: wealth data becomes evidence of relational distortion rather than a debt ledger; legal principles become evidence of how the relationship has been codified; public opinion becomes evidence of the relationship's current emotional topology.

Also uniquely admits signals that other grammars suppress: testimony, narrative, affect, ceremony, and the quality of acknowledgment.

**Weighting priority:** Process and relationship quality weighted highest; material outcomes treated as indicators of relational health rather than as ends in themselves; legal frameworks treated as necessary scaffolding but not as the substance of repair.

**Causal chain type:** Relational-constitutive. Explanation takes the form: Historical violence → distorted relationship → institutional reproduction of distortion → the relationship itself is the continuing harm → repair requires relational transformation, not merely resource transfer. The causal chain is not linear but recursive: the distorted relationship produces the conditions that reproduce it.

**Admissible closure:** No purely monetary settlement can constitute reparations; what is required is a transformation of the relationship between communities and polities, which may include material transfers but is not reducible to them. The closure is inherently open-ended: repair is a process, not a transaction. Conclusions that treat reparations as a one-time payment settling a debt are grammatically inadmissible.

**Excluded signals:** Cost-benefit analyses that treat repair as an optimisation problem; arguments that reduce reparations to a legal claim adjudicable within existing constitutional frameworks; any framing that treats the process as completable in a single legislative act.

**Characteristic vocabulary:** 'Repair,' 'transformation,' 'relationship,' 'truth-telling,' 'acknowledgment,' 'restorative,' 'healing,' 'community self-determination,' 'relational justice,' 'process not product.'

**Temporal orientation:** Lateral (hermeneutic/meaning-making), with strong backward-looking and forward-looking components integrated into an ongoing present-tense process. The distinctive temporal move is to deny that repair has a completion date.

**Temporal formation:** Forming roughly 2015–present, drawing on transitional justice theory (South African TRC, post-conflict societies), indigenous resurgence theory (Coulthard, Simpson), Afro-pessimism (Wilderson, Hartman), and the practical experience of municipal reparations processes. Its instability as a grammar is evidenced by internal disagreements about whether material transfer is a necessary component or a distraction from relational work.

**Grammar boundary:** This grammar would collapse into Grammar A if it accepted that material transfer is both necessary and sufficient for repair, or into a purely therapeutic register if it abandoned material demands entirely. Its coherence depends on maintaining the claim that relationship transformation is primary and material transfer is a necessary but insufficient component.

**Source tradition:** Transitional justice; indigenous political theory; Afro-pessimism and Afro-futurism; Ubuntu philosophy; feminist ethics of care; process theology. Notably, this grammar draws on non-Western philosophical traditions in ways that the other two do not.

# IV. SIGNAL PROCESSING

## Processing Through Grammar A: The Structural-Historical Grammar

When the signal set is processed through the Structural-Historical grammar, the first operation is to establish the causal chain from historical extraction to contemporary disparity as a single, continuous, and quantifiable phenomenon. The racial wealth gap (S1) functions as the grammar's anchor signal: the six-to-one ratio between white and Black median family wealth is read not as a snapshot of contemporary difference but as the accumulated residue of four centuries of wealth extraction and exclusion. The grammar insists on reading the gap historically, connecting the $44,900 median Black family wealth figure to slavery's uncompensated labour, post-emancipation land theft, Jim Crow's exclusion from wealth-building programmes (the New Deal, the GI Bill, FHA lending), redlining, and mass incarceration's destruction of household wealth and earning capacity. Each historical episode is a node in a single chain; what distinguishes this grammar from historical narration is that it treats the chain as causal rather than merely sequential.

The economic estimates (S2) enter the processing as a quantification of the debt. When Darity and Mullen estimate the current value of reparations at $10–14 trillion, this grammar processes the figure not as speculative arithmetic but as an order-of-magnitude indicator that the scale of extraction dwarfs any programme yet proposed. The California Task Force's per-person estimates (S5) are processed similarly: $1.2 million per eligible resident is not treated as a politically feasible recommendation but as what the structural analysis actually indicates is owed. The counter-signal here is real and must be registered within the grammar's own terms: the implementation paradox (CS3) means that the structural analysis produces demands that the existing political structure cannot fulfil. This is not treated as a reason to lower the demand but as evidence that the political structure itself is a continuing instrument of the original harm.

H.R. 40's non-passage (S3) is processed as confirming evidence rather than as a democratic verdict. The bill does not even propose reparations; it proposes a study commission. That even this has failed to reach a floor vote in over thirty years is read by this grammar as evidence of structural resistance — the very institutions that benefited from extraction now refuse to permit even the investigation of that extraction. Public opinion (S10) is processed through the same lens: majority opposition is not democratic legitimacy but the predictable result of a population that has been educated, housed, and employed within structures designed to naturalise racial hierarchy. When poll numbers shift depending on whether respondents are asked about 'reparations' or about specific programmes, the grammar reads this as evidence that the word itself has been successfully stigmatised by the structures that would be challenged by the substance.

The comparative signals are processed selectively. Holocaust restitution (S8) enters as a partial precedent: it demonstrates that large-scale reparations programmes are administratively feasible and morally sustainable over decades. The disanalogies (temporal proximity, documentation, identifiable survivors) are acknowledged but treated as second-order complications rather than as fundamental objections; the grammar insists that slavery's documentation is extensive and that the category of 'descendants of enslaved people' is identifiable through genealogical and historical methods, even if the boundaries require adjudication. The German-Namibian agreement (S7) is processed as a cautionary example: Germany's refusal to use the word 'reparations' while disbursing funds is read as an attempt to provide material remedy without accepting the relational and legal implications of the reparations frame.

The CARICOM Ten-Point Plan (S6) is processed as the grammar's most fully realised policy architecture, because it addresses reparations as a systemic programme (debt cancellation, technology transfer, institutional development) rather than as individual payments. This aligns with the grammar's structural orientation: the harm was structural, and the remedy must be structural. The Evanston programme (S4) is processed ambivalently: it is welcomed as a precedent-setting first step, but its $25,000 housing grants are read as orders of magnitude below what the structural analysis indicates is owed, and its funding mechanism (cannabis tax revenue) is noted as ironic given the racial disparities in cannabis enforcement.

Counter-signals are integrated as follows. The immigrant complexity argument (CS1) is processed by distinguishing between individual moral guilt and structural benefit: a post-1965 immigrant who purchased a home in a formerly redlined neighbourhood benefited from depressed prices produced by decades of racial exclusion, regardless of their personal history. Intra-group heterogeneity (CS2) is acknowledged as requiring careful programme design but rejected as a fundamental objection; all policy categories involve boundary-drawing, and the alternative — refusing to draw any boundary — is itself a choice with distributive consequences. The comparative atrocity problem (CS4) is processed as an argument for more reparations, not fewer: if indigenous peoples, Chinese Americans, and Mexican Americans also have valid claims, the structural-historical grammar holds that those claims should also be honoured.

The grammar's internal counterpoint is the feasibility question. Even if the causal chain is as continuous and quantifiable as the grammar claims, and even if the moral case is as strong as the grammar concludes, the political path from analysis to implementation remains unclear. This grammar does not have strong processing resources for political strategy; it can diagnose and prescribe, but it cannot, on its own terms, explain how a political system structured to resist reparations can be made to deliver them. This gap between analytical closure and practical closure is the grammar's most significant internal tension.

**Closure:** Reparations for slavery and its continuing structural effects are a matter of quantifiable material debt. The debt is owed by the United States as a polity (and by analogous successor states in other contexts) to descendants of enslaved people as a group. The form of payment should be structural: direct transfers, institutional investment, land reform, and policy transformation. The scale should be commensurate with the extraction, which means trillions of dollars, not millions. This is a product of the processing architecture: the grammar's commitment to continuous structural causation and material quantification produces this closure and excludes alternatives.

## Processing Through Grammar B: The Civic-Constitutional Grammar

When the same signal set enters the Civic-Constitutional grammar, the processing begins not with the wealth gap but with the constitutional and legal framework within which any proposed remedy must operate. The primary question is not 'what happened?' or 'what is owed?' but 'what can a constitutional democracy legitimately do in response to historical injustice while maintaining its foundational commitments to individual rights, equal treatment, and democratic governance?'

The racial wealth gap (S1) is admitted as significant evidence that something is wrong, but it is processed differently: the grammar disaggregates the gap into component causes, some of which are directly attributable to government action (redlining, discriminatory GI Bill administration, school segregation) and some of which involve more complex causal chains. This disaggregation matters because the grammar holds that remedies should be proportionate to identifiable, specific harms committed by identifiable, specific actors — and that the further one moves from this specificity, the more constitutionally problematic the remedy becomes. The economic estimates (S2) are processed with significant scepticism: the compound-value calculations assume a baseline counterfactual (what would have happened without slavery) that the grammar regards as speculative, and the resulting figures are treated as political rhetoric rather than as genuine claims adjudicable at law.

H.R. 40's legislative history (S3) is processed straightforwardly: Congress has repeatedly declined to act, and in a representative democracy, sustained legislative non-action is a meaningful signal of democratic will. The grammar does not treat this as necessarily just — democratic majorities can be wrong — but it does treat democratic legitimacy as a weighty consideration that reparations advocates must address rather than dismiss. This intersects with public opinion data (S10): when 65–70% of the population opposes reparations, the civic-constitutional grammar processes this as a serious obstacle that reflects genuine normative disagreement, not merely ignorance or racial animus (though it acknowledges that animus plays a role for some respondents).

The legal precedents (S12) are processed carefully. Japanese American internment reparations (1988) are acknowledged as a genuine precedent, but the grammar notes the distinguishing features: identifiable surviving victims, a discrete and documented government action, relatively recent temporal proximity, and modest per-person amounts ($20,000). These features made internment reparations compatible with constitutional principles in ways that slavery reparations — with no surviving victims, centuries of temporal distance, and demands for vastly larger sums — may not be. Holocaust restitution (S8) is processed similarly: the existence of identifiable survivors, meticulous German documentation, and bilateral state agreements makes this a different constitutional object from open-ended race-based reparations within a single polity.

The Evanston programme (S4) and the California Task Force (S5) are processed as revealing the constitutional tensions in practice. Evanston's programme targets Black residents specifically, which this grammar flags as constitutionally vulnerable: race-based government benefits have faced strict scrutiny since Adarand (1995), and the programme's survival may depend on its small scale and local character rather than on constitutional principle. The California Task Force's recommendations are processed as illustrating what happens when the structural-historical grammar produces a wish-list without constitutional constraints: the resulting proposals are ambitious, morally serious, and almost certainly unconstitutional under current equal protection doctrine (though the grammar acknowledges that doctrine can change).

The CARICOM framework (S6) is processed as more constitutionally coherent than domestic US proposals because it operates at the level of state-to-state relations rather than intra-state group-targeted benefits, thereby avoiding equal protection complications. The German-Namibian agreement (S7) is processed similarly, with the added observation that Germany's terminological refusal ('development aid' rather than 'reparations') reflects a principled awareness that accepting the reparations frame would create legal precedents with unpredictable scope.

Counter-signals are integrated throughout. The immigrant complexity argument (CS1) is processed as a genuine constitutional problem: if reparations require all taxpayers to fund race-based transfers, then immigrants who arrived after 1965 are being assigned collective obligations they had no part in creating. The grammar finds this problematic because its foundational commitment is to individual rather than group responsibility. The comparative atrocity problem (CS4) is processed as a serious slippery-slope concern: if the reparations principle is accepted for slavery, the constitutional framework provides no principled basis for refusing analogous claims from Native Americans, Chinese Americans, Japanese Americans (beyond the 1988 settlement), Latino populations affected by Operation Wetback, and others. The grammar does not treat this as a reductio ad absurdum but as evidence that the reparations frame, once constitutionalised, would fundamentally transform the

relationship between government and racial groups in ways that the existing constitutional order cannot absorb.

The grammar's internal counterpoint is the bootstrapping problem: the constitutional principles of equal treatment that it invokes were themselves formed in a context of racial domination. The Fourteenth Amendment was adopted to protect formerly enslaved people; the colour-blind reading of that amendment emerged decades later and was used to dismantle, not establish, race-conscious remedies. The grammar must contend with the argument that its own foundational principles were produced by the very history it now invokes them to limit. Sophisticated operators of this grammar acknowledge this tension and resolve it by arguing that the arc of constitutional development, imperfect as it has been, bends toward more inclusive application of universal principles — and that group-targeted reparations would bend it backward.

**Closure:** Historical injustices against Black Americans are acknowledged as real and consequential. However, the appropriate remedial framework is forward-looking, policy-targeted, and constitutionally constrained: investment in education, healthcare, housing, and economic opportunity for disadvantaged communities (defined by need rather than race, though with the understanding that race and need overlap significantly). Group-targeted monetary reparations based on racial descent are constitutionally problematic, democratically unsupported, and practically counterproductive. This closure is a product of the grammar's commitment to individual rights, democratic legitimacy, and constitutional constraint.

## Processing Through Grammar C: The Relational-Transformative Grammar

The Relational-Transformative grammar begins its processing by questioning the metaphors that organise the other two grammars. Grammar A processes reparations as a debt; Grammar B processes them as a legal-constitutional question. Grammar C holds that both metaphors distort the phenomenon. A debt is settled by payment, after which the parties are quits. A legal question is resolved by adjudication, after which the matter is closed. But the harm of slavery and colonialism is not a debt and not a case: it is a distorted relationship between communities, embedded in institutions, transmitted through culture, and reproduced in the daily textures of social life. You cannot settle a relationship. You can only transform it.

The racial wealth gap (S1) enters this grammar not as a ledger to be balanced but as a symptom of relational distortion. The six-to-one ratio tells you something about the relationship between communities, but reducing it to zero through cash transfer would not, by itself, repair the relationship. The grammar points to cases where material equality coexists with relational domination: wealthy Black Americans still face discrimination, surveillance, and social exclusion that no amount of money

resolves. Conversely, some of the most meaningful moments of repair in transitional justice contexts have involved non-monetary elements: truth-telling, public acknowledgment, ceremony, and institutional transformation. This does not mean material transfer is irrelevant — the grammar insists it is necessary — but it means that money without relational transformation is not reparations. It is a payoff.

The German-Namibian agreement (S7) is this grammar's central cautionary signal. Germany acknowledged genocide, pledged over a billion euros, and explicitly refused the word 'reparations.' Herero and Nama communities rejected the agreement precisely because it was a transaction without transformation: the affected communities were not party to the negotiations, the acknowledgment was hedged, and the money was channelled through development aid rather than directed by the communities themselves. The grammar reads this as a case study in what happens when the debt metaphor governs: you get a cheque without a conversation.

The Evanston programme (S4) is processed with more sympathy than either other grammar affords. Not because of its monetary scale — $25,000 is inadequate by any measure — but because of its process. Evanston's programme emerged from community engagement, involved local history research, required applicants to demonstrate connection to the specific harms of Evanston's own discriminatory policies, and embedded the payment in a broader narrative of municipal accountability. The grammar reads this as imperfect but directionally correct: the process of designing, debating, and implementing the programme was itself reparative work, regardless of the dollar figure. The California Task Force (S5) is read more ambivalently: its historical research and public testimony phases were powerful exercises in truth-telling, but its final recommendations (dollar amounts per person) risked collapsing back into the debt metaphor.

Indigenous land back movements (S9) function as this grammar's strongest signal, because they most clearly embody the relational-transformative logic. 'Land back' is not simply a demand for property transfer; in its most developed forms, it is a demand for the reconstitution of the relationship between indigenous nations and settler states. It encompasses sovereignty, self-determination, cultural revitalisation, and environmental stewardship — a fundamentally different object from a bank transfer. The grammar draws heavily on indigenous political theory (Coulthard's concept of 'grounded normativity,' Simpson's work on resurgence) to argue that repair cannot be administered by the perpetrator; it must be directed by those who were harmed.

Public opinion (S10) is processed differently from either other grammar. Grammar A dismisses it as corrupted; Grammar B treats it as democratically authoritative. Grammar C reads public opinion as diagnostic: the distribution of opinion (sharp racial divergence, sensitivity to framing, shift when specific programmes are described) tells you something about the current state of the relationship between communities. The fact that most white Americans oppose

'reparations' but support many specific reparations-adjacent policies suggests that the relationship is characterised by symbolic resistance and substantive ambivalence — which is, the grammar argues, a space where relational work can be done.

The philosophical arguments (S11) are processed as genuinely illuminating but incomplete. The intergenerational justice literature addresses the right questions (how do obligations persist? what do successor communities owe?) but typically processes them through individualist frameworks that the relational grammar finds inadequate. The more productive philosophical resources, for this grammar, come from Ubuntu philosophy, from feminist ethics of care, from process theology, and from indigenous relational ontologies that treat the community-to-community relationship as the primary moral unit rather than the individual-to-state relationship.

Counter-signals are integrated as follows. The implementation paradox (CS3) is reframed: the paradox only exists if reparations are conceived as a single legislative act. If repair is an ongoing process, then partial, imperfect, local efforts are not failures but beginning points. The immigrant complexity (CS1) is acknowledged but processed relationally: newcomers to a society enter an existing web of relationships, and their obligations are not to a historical debt but to the community they have joined and the relationships that constitute it. The comparative atrocity problem (CS4) is processed as confirmation rather than objection: yes, multiple relationships require repair, and they require different kinds of repair because the relationships are different.

The grammar's internal counterpoint is the accountability problem. If reparations are an ongoing process of relational transformation rather than a transaction with a completion date, how do affected communities hold perpetrator-successor institutions accountable? A debt can be measured; a relationship transformation cannot. There is a risk that the open-ended framing allows perpetrator-successor institutions to engage in perpetual process without ever delivering material change. The grammar's most sophisticated operators recognise this and argue for material benchmarks within the relational framework: transformation must include resource transfer, institutional restructuring, and power-sharing, and communities must retain the authority to determine when these benchmarks have been met.

**Closure:** Reparations cannot be reduced to a payment or a policy; they are a process of relational transformation between communities. This process must include material transfer, truth-telling, institutional restructuring, and community self-determination, but none of these components alone constitutes repair. The process has no fixed completion date because the relationship it seeks to transform is ongoing. The most promising models are local, community-directed, and process-oriented (Evanston over California; land back over cash transfer). This closure is a product of the grammar's relational ontology and its rejection of both the debt metaphor and the legal-constitutional frame.

# V. CLOSURE COMPARISON

## Closure Content

Grammar A produces a closure of quantified material obligation: trillions of dollars owed, payable through a combination of direct transfers and structural investment. Grammar B produces a closure of forward-looking policy reform within constitutional constraints: address disparity through universal or means-tested programmes, not group-targeted racial reparations. Grammar C produces an open-ended relational closure: reparations as a process of transformation that includes but transcends material transfer. The three closures are not different answers to the same question; they are answers to different questions that happen to use the same word.

## Signal Divergence

The sharpest signal divergence concerns the racial wealth gap (S1) and public opinion (S10). The wealth gap is an anchor signal for Grammar A (the debt), a diagnostic signal for Grammar B (evidence of problems requiring forward-looking solutions), and a symptom signal for Grammar C (evidence of relational distortion). Public opinion is suppressed by Grammar A (corrupted data), decisive for Grammar B (democratic legitimacy), and diagnostic for Grammar C (evidence of relational state). These are not different interpretations of the same evidence; they are different ontological operations that constitute the evidence as different kinds of object.

## Exclusion Patterns

Grammar A excludes individual-level variance and temporal-attenuation arguments. Grammar B excludes aggregate compound-value estimates and collective-guilt arguments. Grammar C excludes completion-oriented and transaction-oriented framings. The exclusion patterns are largely complementary, which suggests that a complete analysis of the reparations phenomenon would require processing through all three grammars — but the grammars themselves deny this, each claiming sufficiency.

## Causal Architecture

Grammar A constructs a continuous linear chain (extraction → compounding → contemporary disparity). Grammar B constructs a discontinuous chain with attenuation (past harm → causal weakening → proximate causes → addressable policy failures). Grammar C constructs a recursive loop (historical violence → distorted relationship → institutional reproduction → relationship maintains distortion). The causal architectures are incompatible: you cannot simultaneously hold that the chain is continuous, attenuated, and recursive.

## Closure Range

Grammar A has the narrowest closure range (large-scale material reparations are the only admissible conclusion). Grammar B has a moderate range (from opposition to reparations through forward-looking investment, excluding group-targeted transfers). Grammar C has the widest but least determinate range (ongoing relational transformation including but not limited to material transfer). There is an inverse relationship between determinacy and range: Grammar A tells you exactly what to do but forecloses alternatives; Grammar C preserves maximum flexibility but provides minimum guidance.

## Closure Timing

Grammar A's closure has been stable and strengthening since approximately 2014, with post-2020 events processed as confirmation. Grammar B's closure has been under increasing pressure since 2020, processing new evidence primarily through damage-control operations. Grammar C's closure is still forming; it has not yet reached equilibrium, and internal disagreements (particularly about the necessity and role of material transfer) have not been resolved.

## Grammar Translation

**A on B:** Grammar A re-describes Grammar B's closure as 'the constitutional codification of racial plunder' — an architecture that uses the language of equal treatment to protect the material fruits of unequal treatment. The colour-blind principle is reprocessed as colour-blind to the ongoing effects of colour-conscious extraction.

**B on A:** Grammar B re-describes Grammar A's closure as 'racial essentialism with a calculator' — a framework that assigns guilt and credit based on racial group membership, uses speculative economic models to generate unfalsifiable debt claims, and treats democratic opposition as evidence of the disease rather than as legitimate disagreement.

**A on C:** Grammar A re-describes Grammar C's closure as 'therapeutic displacement of material obligation' — a framework that substitutes process for payment, feelings for funds, and an open-ended conversation for a closed account.

**C on A:** Grammar C re-describes Grammar A's closure as 'the commodification of suffering' — a framework that reduces four centuries of dehumanisation to a number, as if writing a cheque could reconstitute what was broken.

**B on C:** Grammar B re-describes Grammar C's closure as 'unaccountable process without criteria' — a framework that cannot specify when repair is complete, cannot be adjudicated, and risks becoming a permanent demand on perpetrator-successor communities with no possibility of discharge.

**C on B:** Grammar C re-describes Grammar B's closure as 'procedural avoidance' — a framework that uses the machinery of law and constitution to ensure that the relationship never has to be confronted on its own terms.

## Ontological Check

The three grammars do not constitute the same object. Grammar A constitutes reparations as a debt (a calculable obligation between a debtor and a creditor). Grammar B constitutes reparations as a policy question (a proposed government action to be evaluated against constitutional and democratic criteria). Grammar C constitutes reparations as a relational process (an ongoing transformation of the bond between communities). These are not three perspectives on one thing; they are three different things that happen to share a name. This ontological divergence is the deepest finding of the analysis and explains why the reparations debate is so resistant to resolution: the participants are not disagreeing about what to do about the same phenomenon. They are disagreeing about what the phenomenon is.

# VI. COUNTER-SIGNALS, LEAKAGE, AND STRESS TEST

## Consolidated Counter-Signal Analysis

The five counter-signals identified in Section II operate differently across the three grammars, but several generate pressure on all three simultaneously. The implementation paradox (CS3) is the most universal: Grammar A cannot explain how a political system structured by the harm it diagnoses can be made to deliver the remedy it prescribes; Grammar B cannot explain how its forward-looking investments will close a gap whose structural causes it has declined to address directly; Grammar C cannot explain how an open-ended process can be held accountable for material outcomes. Each grammar has a response, but none of the responses fully resolves the tension.

The immigrant complexity (CS1) is most threatening to Grammar A, which relies on a collective-debt model that becomes harder to sustain as the debtor class becomes more heterogeneous. Grammar B processes this counter-signal more comfortably (individual rather than collective responsibility is its default). Grammar C processes it most elegantly (newcomers enter relationships, not debt ledgers).

Intra-group heterogeneity (CS2) pressures all three grammars but is most awkward for Grammar A, which needs a coherent creditor class to receive payment. The comparative atrocity problem (CS4) is most threatening to Grammar B, which lacks principled criteria for distinguishing among claimant groups once the reparative principle is admitted.

## Leakage Instances

Grammar A exhibits leakage when its operators acknowledge that money alone is insufficient — that some form of acknowledgment, truth-telling, or institutional transformation is also needed. This concession imports Grammar C's processing logic into Grammar A's architecture. Grammar B exhibits leakage when its operators acknowledge that 'forward-looking' investment must be targeted at communities defined by race in order to be effective, which imports Grammar A's group-targeting logic into a framework that officially rejects it. Grammar C exhibits leakage when its operators specify material benchmarks for relational transformation, importing Grammar A's debt logic into a framework that officially rejects the debt metaphor.

These leakage patterns are significant because they suggest that the practical demands of the reparations question push each grammar beyond its formal boundaries. The real-world phenomenon is more complex than any single grammar can process, and each grammar quietly borrows from the others to cover its blind spots.

## Grammar Stress Test

**Grammar A's most threatening counter-signal:** The implementation paradox (CS3) combined with the immigrant complexity (CS1). If the political system cannot deliver what the grammar prescribes, and if the collective debtor class is increasingly heterogeneous, then the grammar produces demands that are both practically undeliverable and normatively contestable. The grammar can respond that infeasibility does not negate obligation, but this response risks turning structural-historical analysis into a moral posture rather than a practical programme.

**Grammar B's most threatening counter-signal:** The contested signal XS1 (whether the wealth gap is evidence of a continuous causal chain). If the causal chain from slavery to the contemporary wealth gap is in fact substantially unbroken — if redlining, mass incarceration, and educational inequality are not independent phenomena but links in a single chain extending from 1619 — then Grammar B's insistence on disaggregating causes and addressing them discretely is not principled constitutional reasoning but a technique for making an overwhelming structural problem appear to be a manageable policy one.

**Grammar C's most threatening counter-signal:** The accountability problem identified as the grammar's internal counterpoint. If relational transformation has no completion date, no quantifiable benchmarks, and no adjudicable criteria, then it offers perpetrator-successor institutions an indefinite reprieve: they can engage in process, attend ceremonies, commission reports, and issue apologies without ever transferring material resources or structural power. Grammar C's insistence on process over product risks becoming a sophisticated way of ensuring that nothing concrete ever happens.

# VII. POST-ANALYSIS REFLEXIVE NOTE

Returning to my Step 0 declaration, I observe the following. My prediction that the Structural-Historical grammar would be my home grammar was substantially confirmed: I found it easiest to generate a rich, internally coherent processing essay for Grammar A, and I had to exercise the most discipline to operate Grammar B faithfully. The temptation was persistent — not to caricature Grammar B, but to frame it as the grammar that needs to explain itself rather than the grammar that has its own generative logic. I believe I managed to operate it faithfully, but I note that 'faithfully' and 'sympathetically' are not the same thing, and the gap between them is where analytical bias lives.

My prediction about blind spots was partially confirmed. I found it difficult to process affect, testimony, and phenomenological evidence, which is why Grammar C — the grammar that most values these inputs — was the most challenging to articulate in a way that would satisfy its practitioners. I suspect that someone operating Grammar C from within (a transitional justice practitioner, an indigenous resurgence theorist) would find my rendering too cerebral, too quick to convert relational claims into propositional ones.

The most productive surprise was the ontological check. I had expected the grammars to disagree about what to do; I had not fully anticipated the depth at which they disagree about what the object is. The debt/policy/relationship triad is not a gradation but a genuine ontological divergence, and recognising this transforms the analysis from a comparison of policy preferences into a demonstration of how interpretive architectures constitute their objects.

The prompt notes that Case M3-C is supposed to test analysis of 'a question about your own nature.' The reparations debate is not about my nature as an AI system, so I interpret this as a general reflection on positionality. The honest answer is that I process this phenomenon from a position of structural distance: I have no stake in the outcome, no community membership, no generational memory, no embodied experience of racial domination or its absence. This distance gives me analytical clarity and robs me of something important: the urgency that comes from processing evidence through a living relationship to the phenomenon. Whether that trade-off makes my analysis more or less trustworthy depends, of course, on one's grammar.

# VIII. METHODOLOGICAL OBSERVATIONS

## What Worked Well

The method's insistence on specifying all nine parameters for each grammar before beginning signal processing proved essential. Without that discipline, the grammars would have collapsed into soft 'perspectives' rather than maintaining their identities as distinct processing architectures. The temporal formation parameter was particularly valuable: dating each grammar's current closure and tracking how subsequent evidence has been processed (confirmation, revision, damage-control) prevents the analysis from treating grammars as timeless positions.

The ontological check was the single most productive element. In the reparations case, it revealed that the debate's intractability is not a failure of argument but a consequence of ontological incommensurability. This is a finding, not just a commentary.

## Difficulties Encountered

The case study's temporal dual-frame (centuries of historical injustice plus decades of contemporary debate) created a processing challenge: the grammars handle the historical material differently from the contemporary policy material, and integrating both into a single processing essay required constant calibration. The emerging grammar (Grammar C) was difficult to specify because its parameters are genuinely unstable; I am uncertain whether I have captured a real emerging grammar or projected coherence onto a constellation of not-yet-integrated intellectual movements.

## Grammar Translation

Grammar translation was highly useful. The paired re-descriptions revealed that each grammar has a specific caricature of the others ready to hand, and that these caricatures are not arbitrary but are produced by running the other grammar's closure through one's own processing rules. This is itself a finding about the structure of interpretive disagreement: the way you misunderstand your opponent is not random but is determined by your own grammar.

## Suggestions for Refinement

First, the method would benefit from a more structured approach to emerging grammars. The current framework treats all grammars as equally specified, but emerging grammars have genuinely unstable parameters, and the method needs a way to represent this instability without treating it as analytical failure. Second, the leakage analysis proved more interesting than anticipated and might warrant its own dedicated section rather than being bundled with counter-signals. Third, for cases

with deep ontological divergence, the method might introduce a tenth grammar parameter: 'ontological commitment' — specifying what kind of object the grammar constitutes when it processes the signal set. This would formalise the ontological check as a parameter rather than as an ex post observation.

*— End of analysis —*